

The Importance of Free Speech

By Ryan Saelens

Why is Freedom of Speech important? This question is analogous to asking, ‘Why is having a thought important?’, ‘Why is a self-governing society important?’, or ‘Why is it important in the fight against censorship and control?’ Freedom of Expression (e.g., speech) is looked at by the Supreme Court to be a “fundamental right within our political system” –a building block for which “nearly every other form of freedom” is built upon. (*Free Speech on Campus*, 26) If we have no way or need of expressing ourselves, then what sense does it make to have laws and rights that function to clarify certain freedoms? To no surprise, it wouldn’t, and if our abilities to freely express ourselves got taken from us tomorrow—we would quickly see how important it is to allow us to think and have thoughts and to have the ability to voice said thoughts; to grow as a people and create a self-government; and to tug back on the rope that is censorship and control.

Everything grows from the seed of thought. Ideas, beliefs, desires, emotions: they all spring forth from the ability to think. But we don’t necessarily always agree with the thoughts that other people have. We sometimes think like one another, but we also have thoughts that are quite different. There are a lot of people that grow to dislike those that don’t think like they do. Sometimes this can be justified: to think it is correct not to murder another, and to dislike someone that thinks otherwise. On the other side of the coin, there are people that think differently, yet work well together. So it seems that we don’t mind that others have thoughts of their own. We only mind when it comprises what we think to be true. But what if having thoughts wasn’t allowed? Sure benefits could follow from this: physical violence goes down because we can’t think about it; verbal violence would fade as well. But then it wouldn’t be

necessary for the laws and rights that have been established for us. We simply wouldn't have a thought to have any care in the world about rules that govern our lives. We would essentially be mindless meatsuits. Consciousness creates thoughts, and thoughts are what make the individual. So if thoughts are taken away, the consciousness collapses, and the essence that truly makes a person different, diminishes. It's important to keep in mind that we have only ever gotten anywhere because someone thought differently, but more importantly because they had the freedom to think.

It's unfortunate, the thick history we have of governments suppressing their people. Limits on speech were set—nothing bad was to be said about the government, or in many older cases The Church. Author, Steve Pinker, argued that “everything we know about the world—the age of our civilization, species, planet, universe; the stuff we're made of; the laws that govern matter and energy; the workings of the body and brain—came as insults to the sacred dogma of the day.” (*Why Free Speech Is Fundamental*) So, it became clear that The Church didn't care for information to be shared that they themselves didn't stumble upon—or hear from God to spread. In many ways a government, our government, is guilty of creating the same acts. We find out the truth about a particular public matter, all the while the government knew about it and set limits on those involved. Fear, since the Greeks and Romans, has been installed by governments to keep people from thinking for themselves; your politicians know best. For many kept their thoughts to themselves; some continued to speak up; some quit having thoughts of their own—becoming a sheep to their political system. When this happens, the government has found a way to censor and control the thoughts and voices of their people. This has been done to persuade elections, and also to stop the spread of information before reaching the general public.

So then how is a healthy self-government supposed to be obtained? We see that this is just another bough attached to the trunk of free expression.

Having the freedom to express oneself is what truly makes the world wonderful. Sure people can act in ways or say certain things that are out-of-line, but that doesn't mean we should take away their ability to express themselves. Chemerinsky and Gillman said it best: "Support for free speech is synonymous with a genuine commitment to democracy, diversity, and change". (*Free Speech on Campus*, 29) So, the best thing we can do for ourselves, and for our society, is to think and be expressive while being mindful of our laws and rights.